claim he later rejected, insisting consideration of the ‘Chinese way’ (using weapons) never crossed his mind:

In spite of all the assertions to the contrary, the Chinese solution never had any standing. It was like this. Up to the 7th and 8th of October, the question never arose of dispersing peaceful demonstrations with the application of armed military force. We looked much more for the so-called security partnership, and it has been shown that this path was the only right one. That has nothing whatever to do with the attitude of Egon Krenz. The orders given for this came from me in my capacity as Chairman of the National Defence Council. I held from the start that guns ought not to be needed. Copies of these orders with regard to Leipzig were sent to all those in charge of operations in the county so that they knew what our attitude would be in such an eventuality.29

Already looking to his place in history, Krenz was keen to stress his role in keeping the peace. ‘On 9 October I was not yet general secretary, but I don’t know about any order of that kind to shoot, nor do I believe there was such an order to shoot,’ neither, he said, had there been any orders about the issuing of live ammunition.30 Krenz remembered holding a telephone conversation with the then First Secretary of Leipzig who told him the director of music at the main concert hall (Gewandhaus) had, together with other public figures, appealed for calm and moderation. In a barbed comment, Honecker later accused his deputy of trying to take credit for the peaceful response in an interview with Bild:

Krenz, later on, wanted to stick some kind of feather in his cap this coincides very much with his contribution to the Federal Republic newspaper Bild story ‘Now I’ll tell everything’. So far as I could tell from this, obviously in ‘Now I’ll tell everything’, the truth mattered to him less than the DM1.5 million he was to receive for the tittle-tattle he engaged in there.31